CRIME
DEEG

SNARING THE DIGITAL DACOITS

Rapidly becoming the new hub of online fraud in the country, a concerted crackdown by the state and the police has helped Rajasthan's Deeg district bring down the menace drastically within six months

By Rohit Parihar

IT **is a brand new district, carved out of Bharatpur, home district of Rajasthan** chief minister Bhajan Lal Sharma, only last year. But Deeg has already gained notoriety as the cybercrime capital of India, overtaking erstwhile hotspots such as Deoghar and Jamtara in Jharkhand; Nawada and Nalanda in Bihar; Nuh in Haryana; and Alwar next door in Rajasthan. The Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C) found that 19 per cent of all reported cases of fraud in February 2024 originated from this outpost in the Mewat region. The anti-cybercrime units of different states were mapping some 225 locations in the district on a daily basis, which stood in first place for four months in a row for the highest number of cybercrime calls originating in India.

The crimes range from the usual phishing scams using fake mobile numbers/ caller IDs and ATM cards, online scams promising financial rewards, sextortion, to such ingenious schemes as fraudulently offering illegal arms and housing on rent and, the most startling of all, money in exchange for a promise to "impregnate young women".

Embarrassed by this surfeit of cybercrime riches, CM Sharma deputed Rahul Prakash, Inspector General of Police, Bharatpur Range, to end this expanding web of crime. And so Operation Anti Virus was launched on February 29, focusing on Deeg. "The CM called me thrice, saying he gets complaints of cyber fraud emanating from Deeg whenever he goes to other states. He asked us to curtail it on priority," says Prakash.

Six months down the line, a proactive approach and careful tracking, along with a ruthless pursuit of criminals, have yielded a sort of a turnaround for the district. At a webinar on July 19, I4C demonstrated that Deeg's share of reported fraudulent calls had fallen to 2,546 by June-end from the February high of 6,530. They had fallen further to 1,501 by August-end. From March to July, Operation Anti Virus saw 189 FIRs being filed against alleged cyber criminals in Deeg, 743 persons arrested and Rs 49.48 lakh recovered in cash. Seven properties on government land, built allegedly with ill-begotten money, were demolished. The police blocked 21,070 SIM cards used to commit fraud and blacklisted 17,935 IMEI numbers, the unique 15-digit identification for a device. Proud of what they have accomplished so far, IG Prakash says the Deeg model could be worth emulating.

DEEG'S DESCENT INTO CYBERCRIME

Deeg typified the wider Mewat region, overlapping with Haryana and proximate to Uttar Pradesh and Delhi, with an old notoriety for petty crime and highway robberies. Then came trade in illicit liquor and stolen vehicles. And when some Deeg criminals discovered the low-risk, high-return business of online crime, they quickly picked up the skills for executing scams involving jobs, relationships, and 'OLX' crimes, where they would copy documents uploaded online for the sale of, say, vehicles and use these to sell the vehicles as their own. They also became adept at ATM card-swapping and the use of "mule

Illustrations by SIDDHANT JUMDE